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Postal Manual Vol V

DISCLAIMER: *This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and the inclusion of recent changes, amendments, and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules, and Regulations, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and students are strongly recommended to refer to official government sources or gazettes for the most reliable and authoritative information.*

Postal Manual Vol V

Chapter 1: Organizational Definitions and Structure

Rule 2. Railway Mail Service (RMS)

The expression "Railway Mail Service" refers to the service responsible for the carriage of mails by rail, road, river, and air, and for the collection and distribution of mails received from Post Offices by Mail Offices and sections.

Rule 5-A. V-SAT Stations

Important Head Post Offices are identified as Very Small Aperture Terminal (V-SAT) Stations. Money orders are transmitted from these Post Offices using V-SAT technology.

Rule 5-B. Extended Satellite Money Order (ESMO)

These stations function as extension counters for the booking and transmission of money orders through V-SAT stations.

Rule 5-C. Hybrid Mail Service

This service involves the electronic transmission of written material from one place to another using computer terminals connected through VSAT. The material can be delivered to one or more addressees at the receiving station.

Rule 9-A. Transit Office

A Transit Office is any Post Office situated on a line of through mail communication that receives and sorts bags intended for offices in advance without opening them.

- **Forward Bags:** Bags forwarded onwards unopened are termed "forward bags".
- **Procedure:** Transit bags addressed to a transit office are opened there. The forward bags contained within are sent onwards, either loose or enclosed in other transit bags.

- **Purpose:** The use of a transit office is to reduce the number of loose bags.

Rule 9-B. Transit Mail Office (TMO)

A Transit Mail Office is a branch of the RMS where closed bags are received and dispatched.

- **Function:** Sorting of letters is **not** done in this unit.
- **In-Charge:** A Mail Agent or Mail Guard is in charge of this unit.
- **Sets:** This office can function in a number of sets depending upon requirements.
 - *Example:* Delhi TMO Set No. 1 works from **06.00 to 14.00** hours.
 - *Example:* Delhi TMO Set II works from **14.00 to 21.40** hours.
- **Night Sets:** If a TMO functions in a night set, the set works throughout the night. Officials working on a particular night will not work the following night; a separate batch relieves them, and these batches work alternatively.

Rule 11-A. Nodal Post Office

In important cities and towns, specific Post Offices are authorized to receive letters from neighboring Post Offices and sort the mail according to a sorting diagram provided by the RMS Superintendents.

- **Purpose:** To reduce peak hour pressure in local sorting offices.
- **Designation:** Such offices are identified as Nodal Post Offices.

Rule 11-B. Central Bagging Unit (Kendriya Bagging Unit)

This Unit is a branch of the RMS Office where bundles prepared by Post Offices or Mail Offices are grouped and enclosed in a direct bag.

- **Workflow:**

1. Post Offices prepare bundles for various destinations (Post Offices, Districts, Circles, or Mail Offices).
2. These bundles reach the Central Bagging Unit (KBU) in 'L' Bags or 'R' Bags.
3. The KBU/CBU opens these bags and groups the bundles by destination (e.g., Circle-wise, District-wise, PO-wise).
4. Bundles are then enclosed in respective bags for the Post Office or Sorting Office concerned for delivery or further transmission.

Rule 12. Returned Letter Office (RLO)

A Returned Letter Office deals with unclaimed, refused articles, and articles without addresses or with undecipherable/incomplete addresses.

- **Current Structure:** The concept of an RLO at every Circle Headquarters has changed. Currently, there are only **4 Zonal RLOs** covering all of India.

Zone	Location
Eastern	Kolkata
Western	Mumbai
Northern	Lucknow
Southern	Chennai

Rule 13. International Mails and Exchange Offices

 **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Provisions regarding Offices of Exchange were amended on 04.04.2022.

1. Office of Exchange (OE)

- Makes up and exchanges international mails with Offices of Exchange of foreign countries after customs clearance.
- Can be an outward OE, an inward OE, or both.

- Maintains accounts relating to international mail exchange and handles inquiries/indemnity cases.

2. Office of Exchange of Transit

- Receives and dispatches only **closed mail bags** addressed to or received from OEs in India and foreign countries.
- Handles foreign origin bags received in "Closed Transit" and forwards them to destination countries.
- Exchanges mail bags with carriers or officials of foreign administrations.

3. Foreign Post Office (FPO)

- An OE where Customs examination, assessment, and clearance of imported/exported goods are carried out.
- Assessment of Customs Duty is done **only** for articles to be delivered within the jurisdiction of that FPO.
- Articles for other jurisdictions are diverted to the appropriate FPO for duty examination.
- Maintains accounts related to customs duty.

4. Sub-Foreign Post Office (SFPO)

- Receives and dispatches international mail (inbound/outbound) to and from mapped offices within the country.
- **No exchange** of mail directly with other countries.
- Conducts Customs examination of international mail assigned to the office and handles assessment/accounting of customs duty.

Rule 14. Transit Sections

Transit Sections are traveling offices of the Railway Mail Service working on Railway or river steamer lines.

- **Officer-in-Charge:** The officer in charge of a set is called a Mail Guard or Mail Agent (SA).
- **Designation:** Sections are numbered serially and designated by the name of the RMS Division followed by the Serial Number (e.g., **DN-1**).

Rule 15. Mail Office

Mail Offices are stationary units of the RMS. Their classification and functions are distinct from Transit Mail Offices (TMOs).

Feature	Sorting Mail Office	Mail Office	Transit Mail Office (TMO)
Content Handled	Deals with contents of Ordinary L Bags	Deals with contents of RL/SP/PL	Deals only with closed bags
In-Charge	Head Sorting Assistant	Head Sorting Assistant	Mail Agent (SA)
Designation	L1U or L2U	NSH/ICH/NPH/PH	MA

Nomenclature:

- Mail offices located at Railway Stations are designated by the station name followed by "RMS" (e.g., **Delhi RMS**).
- Offices not located at stations are designated as Sorting Offices.

Rule 15-C. Press Sorting Office (PSO)

- **Location:** Situated on the premises of a Newspaper.
- **Expenditure:** Wages and establishment costs are borne by the Newspaper publisher, who also provides necessary stationery.
- **Function:** Works to suit the dispatch timing of the newspaper and closes direct letter bags to Post Offices/Sorting Offices.
- **Paper Sorting Office:** Deals **only** with second-class articles like newspapers, magazines, and packets. It denotes L2S (e.g., **PSO Gandhinagar**).

Rules 15 & 18. Record Offices

Administrative units responsible for work papers and staff matters.

Type	HRO (Head Record Office)	SRO (Sub-Record Office)	RO (Record Office)
Location	Headquarters of RMS Division	Same RMS Division (Non-HQ)	Same RMS Division (Non-HQ)
In-Charge	Head Record Officer (HSG-I)	Sub Record Officer (LSG)	Record Officer (SA)
Functions	Keeps work papers of all offices at HQ; Prepares Salary/Contingent bills for entire division	Keeps work papers of all offices under its jurisdiction	Keeps work papers of sections attached to it

Rule 18-A. Bag Office

Units responsible for the management and accounting of bags.

Type	Unit Bag Office (UBO)	District Bag Office (DBO)	Circle Bag Office (CBO)
Entity	Every Post Office (except BOs)	HRO/SRO (exceptionally HO)	Postal Stores Depot
Function	Maintains Day Bag Book; submits daily bag balance to DBO	Maintains bag account for all types (category-wise) for Sorting Offices, TMOs, and UBOs	Inspection of DBO/UBO; Verification of balances; Procurement, repair, and auction of bags

Note: The "D" Section of the Postal Directorate functions as the **Central Bag Office**. It deals only with correspondence relating to the procurement and distribution of bags.

Rule 20. Subsidiary Sorting Assistant

A Sorting Assistant who works within a Sorting Office for only a portion of its working hours to assist a set where the work is heavy is termed a Subsidiary Sorting Assistant.

Rule 21. Sets (Section and Mail Office)

- **Numbering:** Sets are numbered serially. For sections, the serial number is preceded by the section name (e.g., **A-26/Set No. 4**).
- **Uniformity:** Each set of the same section has the same working hours, the same number of officials, and the same mail exchange arrangement.
- **Determination:** The number of sets for a section is determined based on weekly working hours.

Chapter 2: Mail Operations and Bagging Procedures

Rule 24. Labelled Bundles

Labelled bundles are collections of unregistered articles tied together with a check slip. These are considered "not due" items.

- **Station Bundle:** Prepared when there are **15 or more** unregistered articles for a particular station.
- **Territorial Bundle:** Prepared for a specific state, a clearly defined tract of country, or a foreign country when the number of articles is **25 or more**.
- **Sorting Bundle:** Contains unregistered articles for multiple stations.
- **Express Bundle:** Contains articles requiring immediate sorting upon receipt by the section.
- **Deferred Bundle:** Contains articles that can be disposed of later.

Rule 25. Check Slip

A check slip is a label tied to the top of each labelled bundle to identify its nature.

Color Codes:

- **Pink:** Ordinary Station Paid and Unpaid Bundles.
- **White:** Ordinary Sorting Bundles.
 - *Note:* The white check slip is used for both express and deferred bundles. For **Express Bundles**, the slip is marked on the face with **2 diagonal lines in blue pencil**.
- **Blue:** Foreign air mail bundles (marked with the words "Air Mail").

Strip Markings:

- **Green Strips:** For local articles.
- **Yellow Strips:** For Rajdhani Bundles.
- **Blue Strips:** For Metro Bundles.

Rule 25-A. Money Order Check-slip

A specific check-slip (M.O. 70) printed in red ink on white or Badami paper is prescribed for use in preparing money order bundles for dispatch.

Rule 26. Mail Bags

Mail bags are categorized based on their contents and destination:

1. **Station Mail Bags**
2. **Sorting Mail Bags**
3. **Combined Mail Bags**

Note: When a Cash Bag and Register Bag are included inside a Mail Bag, the symbol "F" is marked on the label.

Rule 26-A. Airmail Bag

- **Definition:** A mail bag containing unregistered and registered articles to be carried by any air service under the "All Up Scheme".
- **Bag Type:** A **blue dosuti bag** should ordinarily be used.
- **Weight Limit:** The weight of an air mail bag or air Transit Bag (TB) should not exceed 30 kg.
- **Contents:**
 - The bag must not contain articles not intended for air carriage.

- **Nil Contents:** If there are no articles for dispatch, a bag with 'nil' contents need not be closed. A suitable entry should be made in the delivery bill.
- **Air Covers:** If the number of articles is **less than 50** and there are no insured articles or air parcels, an airmail cover of suitable size should be used instead of a bag.
- **Air Parcels:** When an air parcel is enclosed, the bag label must bear the superscription "C.A.P".
- **Registered Articles:** Should not be enclosed in a bag unless their number **exceeds 25**, or they are bulky, or accompany insured articles. Otherwise, they should be tied crosswise with the registered list and a check-slip marked '**REGISTERED**'.

Rule 27. Registered Bundle

A registered bundle is prepared when the number of registered articles is **greater than 2** (i.e., **minimum 3 articles**).

Rule 28. Registered Bag

- **Contents:** Contains cash bag, ordinary and V.P. registered letters/packets, insured envelopes, registered/insured bundles, and money order bundles tied with a check-slip and a registered list.
- **Classification:** It is a **Due Bag**.
- **Cash Bag Procedure:** If a registered bag contains a cash bag, the enclosing mail bag label is indicated by the symbol 'F'. The registered list will bear the impression of the Treasury Date Stamp or Round MO Stamp.

Rule 29. Insured Bundle

An insured bundle is prepared when the number of insured articles is **greater than 1** (i.e., **minimum 2 articles**).

- **Dispatch:** Dispatched inside the registered bag with remarks in the registered list.

- **Separate Bag:** If the number of insured letters/bundles for a Mail Office usually exceeds 10, a separate insured letter bag may be prescribed as a separate due bag.

Rule 30 to 37-A. Classification of Bags

Bags are broadly classified into "Due Bags" (periodical/regular) and "Unusual Bags" (ad-hoc).

Due Bags	Unusual Bags
Transit Bag	Parcel Bag
Account Bag	Packet Bag
BO Bag	Cash Bag
Registered Bag	Special Bag
	Camp Bag

Rule 40 & 41. Operational Definitions

Term	Definition	Example
Changing Station	Where the beats of two Transit Sections join.	Yoga Express (Haridwar to Ahmedabad): DN-1-Out ends at Delhi; J-3-IN starts from Delhi to Ajmer.
Connecting Section	An RMS section working in a train in immediate connection with another train containing another RMS section.	A-43 IN connecting with J-3 OUT .

Rules 46 & 47. Orders

- **A Orders:** Issued by the Superintendent, RMS prescribing changes in **sorting lists**.
- **B Orders:** Issued by the Superintendent, RMS for guidance on all subjects **except** alterations in sorting lists.

- *TB Orders*: The letter 'T' is prefixed to 'B' orders issued regarding camp articles and camp bags for high officials on tour.

Rule 52-A. Due Mails and Sorting List

- **Due Mail List**: Shows the details of bags to be received and dispatched by a Mail Office or Transit Section.
- **Sorting List**: Shows:
 1. Offices for which mail bags and registered bags are to be made up.
 2. Offices to which parcel mail articles may be sent direct and the manner of dispatch.

Rule 56-A. Late and Too Late Letters

- **Late Letters**: Letters posted in a Post Office, Mail Office, or letter box after the closing hour with a prescribed late fee.
- **Too Late Letters**: Letters posted after the closing hour **without** the prescribed late fee.

 **LEGISLATIVE NOTE**: The Late Fee has been abolished vide **GSR-912(E)** dated 29.12.2022.

Chapter 3: General Rules and Procedures

Rule 57-A. Trial Cards

Trial cards are service Post Cards (M 26(a)) employed to determine the relative advantage of alternative mail routes or the cause of detention to articles.

- **Format**: A trial card contains the following columns on the back:
 1. Source of receipt
 2. Remarks, misconnection, etc.

3. Manner of disposal
 4. Date stamp of the Office or Section
 5. Signature of Head Sorting Assistant/Postmaster/Supervisor
- **Disposal:** It is returned in a service cover to the issuing officer and should **not** be included in any station bundle.

Rule 58. Latest Hours for Posting

- **Night Mails:** The latest hour of posting will ordinarily be **6 p.m.**
- **Day Mails:** Thirty minutes before the hour fixed for the closing of the mail.
- **Railway Forwarding:** Mails to be forwarded by Railway should ordinarily reach the station **10 minutes** before the train's arrival.

Rule 59. Clearance of Letterboxes

Letterboxes of a Post Office or Mail Office should be cleared at convenient intervals during the day to expedite dispatch preparation.

Rule 74 & 75. Bag Classifications

Feature	Plural Mail Bag	Extra Mail Bag
Category	Due Bag	Unusual Bag
Usage	Used as a Registered bag	Used as an Unregistered bag

Rule 76/2. Inland Air Mail Delivery

- **Documentation:** Six copies of the inland air mail delivery bills [M-57, M-57(a), M-57(b)] must be prepared for each port of call.

- **Distribution:**

1. **1st Copy:** Sent to the Air Mail Accounts Section of the Postal Directorate.
2. **4 Copies:** Handed over to the Air Carrier Agent along with the mails.
3. **Office Copy:** Retained with work papers, bearing the Agent's receipt signature.

Rule 85. Distinguishing Marks

Certain numbers must be preceded by distinguishing letters:

- **Insured Articles:** "Ins"
- **V.P. Articles:** "V.P."
- **Registered/Insured Bundles:** "R.B." or "I.B."
- **Postal Service Registered Articles:** Cipher "O"

Rule 103 & 103-A. Postmarks and Seals

- **Custody:** Impressions of round/oblong money order stamps and unpaid stamps are kept in a separate book of postmarks under the Postmaster's personal custody.
- **Cleaning:** The cleansing of seals and stamps must be recorded daily in the Postmaster's order book (HO), Error Book (SO), or Rough Notebook (RMS).

Rule 107. Stamping Rules

- **Two Stamps:** Defaced by a single impression so the date stamp covers both, with the greater portion falling on the cover.
- **Blocks:** For a block of four stamps (square shape), one neat impression at the center suffices.

- **Foreign Articles:** If stamps on inward foreign articles were not cancelled by the office of origin, they should **not** be date-stamped. Instead, cancel them with a thick stroke in ink or indelible pencil.

Rule 111-A. Foreign Postage Deficiency

Offices of Exchange must impress a "T" stamp on the middle upper front of unpaid/insufficiently paid articles. The amount equal to **twice the deficient postage** must be written in legible figures.

Rule 135. Weight Limits for Mails

Carrier/Type	Maximum Weight
Letter Mail Runner (Main Line)	14 Kg
Parcel Bag (RMS Trolley)	37 Kg
Postman/Village Postman	10 Kg (includes parcels/cash)
Special Parcel Runner	14 Kg per parcel (Max 28 Kg per man)

Rule 136. Supply of Due Mail & Sorting Lists (M-9)

- **Post Offices (Direct RMS Communication):** Supplied by the Superintendent of RMS Division.
- **Other Offices:** Supplied by the Superintendent of Post Offices.
- **Village Sorting Lists (M-52):** Prepared and supplied to HO/SO/BO by the Sub Division Head.

Rule 145. Record of Irregularities

- **Post Offices:** Maintain an **Error Book**.
- **RMS Sorting Assistants:** Maintain a **Rough Notebook**.

Rule 147. Interception of Letters

Interception requires orders from the Member (O), Head of Circle, or Regional Head.

- **Emergency:** The Divisional Head may order interception but must inform the competent authority within **3 days**. Confirmation must be obtained within **7 days**, or the action ceases.

Rule 148. Redelivery and Address Alteration

- **Fee:** A fee of Rs. 6/- applies for recalling an item or altering the address/addressee name without the addressee's consent.
- **Free Alteration:** The addressee may alter the address **free of charge** if the new address is within the delivery area of the same Post Office.

Rule 155. Half-Yearly Enumeration Returns

- **Period:** Conducted during the second week of **February** and **August** (from **8th** to **21st**, both days inclusive).
- **Submission:** A copy of the return must be forwarded by the **15th day** to the Head of Circle (by HOs) or to the Head Office (by SOs).

Chapter 4: Investigation and Weighment**Rule 172-A. Investigation of Offenses**

 **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Legal references have been updated to align with the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

- **Cognizable Cases (e.g., robbery, theft):** Once information is given to the Police under Section 154 CrPC (Now **Section 173 BNSS**), action is controlled by the Police.
- **Non-Cognizable Cases (e.g., forgery):** Departmental investigation must begin immediately. If police aid is required, the matter is placed before a Magistrate under Section 155 CrPC (Now **Section 174 BNSS**).

Rule 175. Monetary Limits for Investigation

The authority competent to handle loss and fraud cases depends on the monetary value involved.

Level of Investigation Officer	Revised Monetary Limit (w.e.f. 23.09.21)
Inspector / ASPOS	Up to Rs. 2 Lakh
Divisional Head / Chief/Senior PM	Above Rs. 2 Lakh up to Rs. 5 Lakh
AD / APMG (Regional/Circle Office)	Above Rs. 5 Lakh up to Rs. 10 Lakh
Director Postal Services & above	Above Rs. 10 Lakh

Rule 226. Weighment System

A system on Indian Railways where closed bags are conveyed in luggage vans without a weight limit.

- **Charges:** Mails are charged by weight.
- **Payment:** Half-yearly for regular daily service; Quarterly for occasional dispatches.

Rule 234. Half-Yearly Weighment of Bags

- **Dates:** Weighment is conducted on **21st January** and **21st July** of each year.
- **Procedure:** A statement in **Form M-105** is prepared in quadruplicate.
 - **Original & Duplicate:** Handed to the Stationmaster.
 - **Triplicate:** Forwarded to the Superintendent, RMS.

